

Mailbox Cleanup - Operator Guide

Offboarding a leaver's mailbox: hold it, delete the account, prove the mail is still there

When someone leaves the company, their mailbox has to be kept for seven years but their licence has to be freed up. This process does both safely: it puts the mailbox on a legal hold, deletes the person's account, and then proves the mail is still there and can still be searched. The mailbox becomes what Microsoft calls an **inactive mailbox** - preserved, searchable, and costing nothing.

Use it whenever HR confirms a leaver, for one person or for a list. It takes about half a day of elapsed time because two of the steps involve waiting for Microsoft to catch up; the actual work is under an hour.

You do not need to know PowerShell. The assistant walks you through 41 steps, one at a time. At each step it prints the exact command, you paste it into your window and press Enter, and you paste the result back (or tell it which file was written). It reads the result, tells you in plain words whether it looks right, and only then moves on. If something does not look right, it stops.

Before you start

- An admin account that is an **Exchange Administrator** (or Global Administrator). You will sign in with it three times; a browser window opens each time.
- The list of people being offboarded - one email address, or a spreadsheet saved as CSV with their addresses in it. Any column name works; the assistant finds it.
- A ServiceDesk Plus ticket, or permission to open one. A ticket helps but never blocks the work: if ticketing cannot be reached, the assistant says so once and keeps the record in its closing report instead.
- A free licence seat for each person who does not already have an E3 licence. The hold needs one until the account is deleted, and the seat comes back afterwards.
- **Everything this process needs is included.** There is nothing to download, install or set up first. At step 4 the assistant checks what is present on your PC and, if anything is missing, asks you once - "**Shall I install these under your user profile?**" - and installs it under your own profile. It never asks for an administrator prompt and never installs machine-wide. The Microsoft modules take a few minutes each; a pause is not a hang.
- Two folders are created for you: **C:\scripts\reports** for the files you attach to the ticket, and **C:\scripts\logs** for the detailed logs. You do not need to make them.

The blue window rule

Every command in this process is pasted into a **blue Windows PowerShell window**. Open the Start menu, type **Windows PowerShell**, and open the blue icon whose title bar says **Windows PowerShell** - not the one that says PowerShell 7, and not an administrator window. Run it as yourself.

The very first thing the assistant asks you to paste is **\$PSVersionTable.PSEdition**. If the window replies **Desktop**, you are in the right place. If it replies **Core**, close that window and open the blue one.

One step - the sync at step 30 - runs on the server AWSPRDINFAD01. You connect to it with Remote Desktop, open the same kind of blue Windows PowerShell window there, paste two lines, and then come back to your own PC. Everything else is on your own PC.

The one rule: never remove a licence

The seat is freed by **deleting the account**, never by removing the licence. Removing the licence from a live mailbox silently deletes the mailbox and Microsoft purges it 30 days later - **even if it is on hold**. Deleting the account while the hold is in place is what turns the mailbox into a preserved inactive mailbox.

If you ask the assistant to "just remove the licence", it will refuse and explain why. That refusal is the process working. The reports it produces carry a column called `SafeToRemoveLicense` that always says No, for the same reason.

Phase A - Setup (steps 1 to 12) - nothing changes yet

- 1. Who is leaving?** Give the assistant one address or the path to your CSV. It reads the list back to you - "3 mailboxes: a, b, c. Correct?" - and waits for your yes.
- 2. The list is normalised.** The assistant tidies your list into the exact file the hold script needs, at `C:\scripts\reports\holdlist.csv`, and tells you about any row it could not use. You decide whether to continue with the good rows or fix the file.
- 3. The ticket.** "Do you have a ServiceDesk Plus ticket for this, or should I open one?" If it opens one, it shows you the title and the list first and waits for your yes. Every later note goes to this ticket. If ticketing is not reachable, it tells you once and carries on - the record goes in the closing report.
- 4. Your PC is checked.** Read-only: PowerShell edition, the Microsoft modules, the two folders, network reachability. Anything missing is listed in plain words.
- 5. Missing pieces are installed** - only if step 4 found any, and only after you say yes once. Under your profile, no administrator prompt. It then re-checks and shows you what was installed and where.
- 6. Open your blue window.** Paste `$PSVersionTable.PSEdition` and confirm it says Desktop. Then the assistant asks for the one thing it cannot know: the email address you sign in to Microsoft 365 admin with. Every command after that arrives complete - nothing else is set up or typed by hand.
- 7. Connect to Exchange Online.** A browser window opens; sign in as your admin account. Good looks like one mailbox row and no red text.
- 8. Connect to Microsoft Graph.** Second sign-in. Good looks like your account name and four permission scopes listed. If the browser never appears, the assistant gives you a device-code version instead.
- 9. Connect to Purview (Security and Compliance).** Third sign-in. Good looks like two rows, both saying Connected.
- 10. Your roles are checked,** in the same window you just connected in. Good looks like PASS for Exchange Administrator. A FAIL for eDiscovery Manager on a first run is normal - step 13 fixes it. A FAIL for Exchange Administrator cannot be fixed here; the assistant stops and tells you who to ask.
- 11. The list file is read back** the way the hold script will read it. The count must match what you said at step 1.
- 12. Licence seats are counted.** There must be at least as many free E3 seats as people on the list who lack one. If there are not, the process stops here rather than half-finishing.

Phase B - Preserve (steps 13 to 23) - reversible

- 13. You are made an eDiscovery Manager.** This lets the later search steps see the mail. The assistant asks before doing it.
- 14. Write down the time.** The eDiscovery role takes 30 to 60 minutes to reach Microsoft's search service. Until then every search returns zero with no error message - there is nothing to debug, only to wait. The assistant will not run the search before the hour is up.

15. **Each mailbox's current hold state is read.** Good looks like no hold yet. If a mailbox turns out to be a meeting room or equipment mailbox, the list is wrong and the assistant stops to ask.
16. **Dry run of the hold.** The hold script runs in what-if mode and lists exactly what it would do to each address. Nothing changes. Never skipped.
17. **The hold is applied.** The assistant says "This applies a seven-year hold to N mailboxes and assigns a temporary seat to any that lack one. Reversible. Continue?" On yes, the script runs. It may pause for up to five minutes waiting for a new licence to take effect - let it. Result file: C:\scripts\logs\M365OffboardingHold-(time).csv.
18. **Reconnect.** The script closes your connection when it finishes (a known quirk). The assistant prints the reconnect lines; paste them.
19. **The hold is verified** by reading every mailbox again. Good looks like `LitigationHoldEnabled = True` and a duration of 2555 days on every row. Any row that is not True is redone before going further.
20. **Wait for the hour from step 14 to pass.** You can do other work. The assistant will not "just try" early.
21. **Baseline count.** For each mailbox, the preservation script records how many items it holds and confirms a search can find them. Good looks like `Verdict = PreservedReadyToDelete` and `SafeToDeleteAccount = True`. Write down the item count - step 34 compares against it. Result file: C:\scripts\logs\MailboxPreservation-(time).csv.
22. **Reconnect** again - same lines as step 18.
23. **The baseline goes on the ticket:** per mailbox, item count, size, hold tag, and the two result files.

Phase C - Delete (steps 24 to 31) - THIS CANNOT BE UNDONE

Everything before this point can be reversed. Deleting an account cannot, after 30 days. The assistant will not print the delete command until every check below has passed and you have typed a confirmation phrase - and it deletes **one account first**, checks it all the way through Phase D, and only then comes back for the rest.

24. **Sign-off report.** The status script reports whether each mailbox is ready for stage 2. On a fresh hold it normally says not ready, because the standard handover window is 30 days on hold. The assistant asks whether this is a training run before shortening that window, and records your answer.
25. **Reconnect** - same lines as step 18.
26. **Only mailboxes marked `Stage2Ready = True` continue.** The assistant tells you which are in, which are out, and why. If none are in, Phase C ends here.
27. **Where does each account live?** Most accounts here are created in the on-premises directory and copied to the cloud. Those must be deleted on-premises and then synced; deleting them in the cloud alone is undone by the next sync. The assistant records the answer for each person.
28. **Sign-off goes on the ticket:** the list cleared for deletion, on-prem or cloud for each, and **the name of the person who approved the deletion.** The assistant asks you for that name. When ticketing is available, nothing proceeds until the note is on the ticket.
29. **The gate.** The assistant tells you how many accounts, what is kept (the mail, on hold, searchable for seven years) and what is lost (sign-in, OneDrive files, Teams chats, group memberships). To proceed you must type exactly **DELETE** followed by the number, for example **DELETE 3**. Typing yes, ok, or pressing Enter does not proceed - it stops, and nothing is deleted.
30. **Delete the first account only.** For a cloud-only account the assistant prints one Remove command with a Y/N prompt. For an on-premises account it prints the Remove-ADUser command for your PC, then says: connect to the server **AWSPRDINFAD01** with Remote Desktop, open the same blue Windows PowerShell window there,

paste the two sync lines (**Import-Module ADSync** and **Start-ADSyncSyncCycle -PolicyType Delta**), then come back to your own PC.

31. **Confirm the account is gone** from the cloud directory and sitting in its 30-day recycle bin. For an on-premises account this can take one sync cycle, about 30 minutes. If it is still there after that, the on-premises delete did not happen - the assistant will not delete it in the cloud instead.

Phase D - Check (steps 32 to 36) - read-only

Microsoft can take a few hours to convert the mailbox after the account is deleted. These steps only read.

32. **Is the mailbox now inactive?** Good looks like the mailbox listed as inactive with the hold still True. The assistant records its ExchangeGuid - from now on that number, not the email address, identifies the mailbox. If the mailbox shows up as soft-deleted instead, the hold was not in place when the account was deleted; the assistant stops everything and switches to the Restore guide, path 4.
33. **Did the hold survive?** The key check. Good looks like `LitigationHoldEnabled = True`, 2555 days, and the hold tag intact on the inactive mailbox.
34. **Count against the baseline.** The preservation script runs again on the inactive mailbox. Good looks like `Verdict = InactivePreserved` (this is success, not a warning) and an item count that matches or exceeds step 21. Then reconnect.
35. **Three confirmation lookups** - everything this process has ever held, every inactive mailbox, and every mailbox on hold in the tenant, exported to `C:\scripts\reports\LitigationHold-Confirmation-(time).csv` for the record.
36. **Did the seat come back?** The licence count should have dropped by the number of accounts deleted. If more accounts are waiting from step 30, the assistant returns to step 29 for them now.

Phase E - Search and export (steps 37 to 41)

37. **Prove the deleted mailbox is still searchable.** A compliance search runs against an account that no longer exists. Good looks like `Status = Completed` and roughly the same item count as step 21. That is the whole process proven.
38. **Read the mail, if needed,** in the Purview portal: eDiscovery, create a case, create a search, tick include inactive mailboxes, run, review sample. The assistant gives you the clicks.
39. **Export only if genuinely needed,** from the portal via a review set. There is no command for this any more. Prefer not to export: if a manager just needs to read the mail, the Restore guide's path 2 copies it into a shared mailbox with proper access control. An export is a liability the moment it exists.
40. **If anything was exported,** the ticket records who asked, who approved, why, where it is, and when it will be deleted.
41. **Close out.** The final ticket note lists every mailbox with its state, hold, before-and-after counts, the seat change, every file path, and anything that was not verified. The assistant asks before closing the ticket - it is yours to close.

Where the files are

- **C:\scripts\reports** - the tidy list (holdlist.csv), the preflight report, and the confirmation exports. These are what you attach to the ticket.
- **C:\scripts\logs** - the detailed log and result file from each step that ran a check, named after the check and the time it ran.

- Both folders are created for you the first time they are needed. There is nothing else to find: every command you paste arrives complete.

When something goes wrong

1. **Stop.** Do not press Enter again and do not re-run the command. Several steps are safe to repeat, but you do not need to decide which - the assistant does.
2. **Copy the red text exactly** as it appears in your window and paste it to the assistant. It needs the exact wording, not a description of it.
3. **Attach the report** from C:\scripts\reports (and the matching log from C:\scripts\logs) to the ServiceDesk Plus ticket, so the next person can see what happened.
4. **Two things that look like failures and are not:** a search that returns zero items within an hour of step 13 is the role still propagating - wait; and the status report saying Stage2Ready = False on a fresh hold is the 30-day handover window working as designed.

If a mailbox ever shows as soft-deleted rather than inactive, a 30-day clock is running. Tell the assistant immediately and switch to the Mailbox Restore guide, path 4.

Need help?

Anything the assistant cannot fix - a missing Exchange Administrator role, a mailbox that does not appear after several hours, a sync that does not complete - goes to the Exchange administrator or Global Administrator through the ServiceDesk Plus ticket, with the report attached.